Preparing students for high-stakes assessment

Can students practise before high-stakes assessment?

LANGUAGE / ASSESSMENT

ONE-PAGE TEACHING GUIDE

WHAT IS IT?

Low-stakes activities scaffold disciplinary communication

WHY DOES IT MATTER?

University contains many hidden rules: what “critical analysis” means, what a rubric is really asking for, when it is acceptable to ask for help, or what counts as “professional” behaviour. If those rules remain unspoken, familiarity can be mistaken for capability.

THE STUDENT EXPERIENCE

- “Everyone else seems to know rules nobody has explained.”
- “I understand the topic, but not what I am being asked to do.”

HOW CAN I DO IT?

- Let students practise unfamiliar genres before they are graded heavily.
- Use short, low-stakes opportunities to build vocabulary and confidence.
- Treat these activities as part of the learning pathway, not add-ons.

EXAMPLE IN PRACTICE

Before a major oral presentation, students complete a brief low-stakes explanation activity and receive feedback on communicating to the intended audience.

STARTING POINT TO ADAPT

For this assessment, we aim to give students supported practice with the language and task type before high-stakes assessment. The learning outcomes being assessed are [insert outcomes].

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View the Influential Communicators example

Creating and using rubrics

Feedback for learning